

was a decent high jumper — my personal best was 1.96m. I always wanted to get over two metres. I think if I had jumped for one more year, I would have made it. But then it was time to switch to javelin.

I also jumped about 14 metres in the triple jump at the U-18 level. People said I could have been a good decathlete, but in Jena — the place where I grew up and did my training — we never had the opportunity to do the pole vault because our gym wasn't tall enough.

Javelin throwing isn't a full-time career in Europe. So how do you manage?

I understood very early on that by just throwing javelins I wasn't going to make a living for me or my family. So I work with sponsors. I'm an ambassador for different brands. I also do management coaching for leaders of big businesses. I focus on this especially in the fall, which is the off-season and when I have a bit more time on my hands. It's definitely time-consuming, and I know that if I were in another country, I'd probably treat my sport a bit differently — I'd allocate my time differently as well. These days, I'm usually up by six, sending and replying to emails. Once I finish that part of my job, I move on to my other job — javelin training.

I enjoy both sides of my work. I love it when big companies call me. I was recently contacted by Allianz and BMW. I enjoyed being able to spread the word about javelin throwing, but in most cases, they wanted me to speak about elite performance. Most people are happy with being average, but I believe there's amazing value that can be brought from the Olympic side of things into society and business.

What do you enjoy the most about your life right now?

Beyond sport and business, my partner and I also started a farm in 2020. We teach people about vegetables, how to live a natural life, and how to nourish the body properly. From time to time, we even host school visits. I really enjoy having the freedom to be in the



garden at lunchtime and to raise a healthy family. On top of that, I get to have a good workout every day — and all of this makes me really happy.

Javelin throw used to be dominated by European throwers, but now there's talent from all over the world.

There was always talent — it just needed a spark. Neeraj was that spark that ignited the flame in India, and now there's a huge talent pool in the country. I think there's another reason too. Here in Germany, performances in events like the javelin throw aren't appreciated as much. In a country like India, your performance gets rewarded. I think that — along with the growing passion for the sport, the time

invested in it, and the sheer mass of people — helps the sport grow.

I also have another theory: cricket has played a huge role in the development of javelin talent. In Germany, the sporting culture is built around football. In India, it revolves more around cricket, which is far more related to javelin than football is. So, it makes sense that cricket-playing nations would have a bigger talent pool. Some people might say the right leg swing is like a football kick, but honestly, football has nothing to do with javelin.

Germany had some excellent throwers, but now, apart from Weber, there doesn't seem to be much talent coming through.

I don't mind. I love that there's an international community of throwers. It doesn't matter much to me where people come from — I just want them to be respectful and to enjoy seeing what the human body can achieve in this sport. I've had connections to so many countries and training groups, and I love seeing them all do well.

German javelin is doing okay, but because we had so much talent coming through at the same time — me, (Andreas) Hofmann, (Johannes) Vetter, and before us Bernhard Seifert — it made it hard for the next generation. We created a big youth gap. Sure, we inspired a lot of young throwers by performing well, but we were too good for too long. The younger guys never really had the chance to step up, and eventually, they quit. We've seen the exact same thing happen in Finland. They had a lot of success in javelin, and then there was this huge gap. It's just the nature of things.

What's the one thing you're looking forward to doing in India?

Well, I hope to try Indian food, even though I still need to see what's on the plate first! By German standards, we already eat Mediterranean and spicy food at home, including Asian cuisine. So I'm okay with spices. But I'd never go crazy, especially not before a competition.